And yet, three years later in 1998, she was Congress president, sparking off a furious debate over her foreign origins. She was probably prepared for the attack, but perhaps was not ready for just how personal it would get. I saw a flash of fury when I asked her the question soon after she took over the party leadership. ‘I feel 100 per cent Indian,’ she said. ‘They are attacking me because they have nothing else to criticize me for.’ The lonely and injured widow-of-Rajiv image came to the fore—Sonia played the victim card to perfection to outsmart senior leaders like Sharad Pawar who had raised the foreign origins issue.

While she could be gentle and genteel in private conversation (she liked to discuss art and culture), her political persona was marked by a ruthless streak. It was clear that she did not forget or forgive easily—she did not attend Rao’s funeral nor did she allow his body to be brought to the Congress headquarters or a samadhi for him in Delhi. ‘Sonia’s world is divided into loyalists and those who are not with the family. Her political and even personal choices are determined by this,’ is how a senior Congressman explained her behaviour. Dr Singh, as a docile, almost servile ‘loyalist’, was made for Sonia; a Rao or a Sharad Pawar would never be socially or politically acceptable to her as they simply did not pass the rigorous loyalty test to a family in which she had subsumed her entire being.

In December 2005, I did a fairly extensive interview with Mrs Gandhi, a rare occurrence since she generally refused to speak to the media. I had extracted a promise from her when I was setting up CNN-IBN that she would give us an interview in our launch phase. She kept her word. I asked her about whether she had any regrets about turning down the prime ministership. ‘No, not at all,’ she said with a quiet firmness. ‘Manmohan Singh is doing a fine job as prime minister. I have full faith in him.’ I asked her to respond to the charge that she was dictatorial and was remote-controlling the government. In a moment of candour, she smiled, ‘Not dictatorial. In fact, sometimes I feel I am too democratic and seek too many opinions before taking a decision.’